Reed College Institutional Review Board (IRB)
IRB Submission Form

This form is organized in the following way; please complete the sections that align with your category of review:

- Sections A and B: all review categories (Exempt Categories 1, 2, 3, and 4; Expedited; Full)
- Sections C, D, E, and F (Exempt Categories 2 and 3; Expedited; Full)
- Section G (Expedited and Full)

We highly recommend that you use the IRB's Pre-Submission Checklist when preparing your proposal.

Software Requirements:

This is a protected fillable form. You must use the desktop version of Microsoft Word to complete this form. Microsoft 365 is available to Reed students, faculty, and staff at no additional cost. Visit https://www.reed.edu/cis/help/office.html for instructions on obtaining a Microsoft 365 account through CUS.

IRB Submission Cover Page

Project Title: Transfeminine Interactional Styles and Experiences
Submission Date: Oct 29, 2025
Name of Primary Investigator (student or faculty): Wren Arbor (Wren King in IRIS)
Primary Investigator Email Address: wren.arbor@reed.edu
Department: Linguistics
Faculty Advisor (if student is primary): Allison Casar
Faculty Email Address (if student is primary): acasar@reed.edu
Additional Researchers (if applicable):
Please indicate your agreement to the following by signing below:

> *I will promptly report changes in the proposed study and any unanticipated problems involving risks to participants, including adverse reactions, to the Institutional Review Board.*

Electronic Signature of Primary Investigator (typed name): Wren King

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***If you are a student, please note that your faculty advisor is expected to review a full draft of your proposal in advance of submission, and you should incorporate your advisor's feedback. Once submitted, the proposal will be forwarded to your faculty advisor for an electronic signature of approval, and then it will be sent to the committee for review.**

If your submission is **similar to** a submission that has been approved previously (within the past two academic years), please identify that proposal by Project Name and Primary Investigator.

Project Name:
Primary Investigator:
Approximate Date of Approval:

A. SUMMARY (required for all review categories)
Provide a brief summary (one paragraph) of the research project. The summary should describe the specific purpose of your engagement with human subjects, how you expect to conduct that engagement, with whom, and the expected outcomes of those interactions.

This project compares transfeminine people's voices when talking to a cisgender person to their voices when talking to a transgender person in order to gain an understanding of gender-related interactional dynamics, the hardships transgender people face, and their ways to navigate a transphobic world. In order to do this, I plan to recruit three types of participants: four transfeminine speakers, one trans woman conversation partner, and one cis woman conversation partner. First, I will audio record loosely structured casual conversations between each participant and each conversation partner. Then, participants will complete a survey which asks optional questions about their linguistic background, race background, their gender and sexuality identities, and, if any, their experience with medical gender-related and/or speech-related therapies. Finally, I will conduct interviews with each participant, in which I will ask follow-up questions about their survey responses, and ask, to the level of their comfort, for elaboration on their trans experience, feelings about the voice, and experiences with transphobia. Audio recordings of conversations between participants will then be transcribed and subject to acoustic analysis to determine context-based differences in vocal gender presentation. Audio recordings of interviews may also be transcribed. With additional consent, redacted forms of their transcripts may be quoted or excerpted and may be subject to discourse analysis. From these analyses, a better understanding of how gender is performed differently to those with different expectations of gender will be gained.

B. BASIC PROTOCOL INFORMATION (required for all review categories)

1. The following populations require special consideration. Please review this list and follow the relevant instructions:

- Children (individuals <18 years). If your research exposes children to risky or deceptive interventions, your proposal requires **FULL** review. All research involving children must include **APPENDIX A.**
- Individuals who, for any reason, cannot give informed consent. Your proposal requires **FULL** review.
- Clinical populations. Your proposal requires **FULL** review.
- Incarcerated populations. Your proposal requires **FULL** review.
- Research conducted outside the US. Please complete **APPENDIX B.**
- Non-English speakers. Please complete the **LANGUAGE ISSUES** section of **APPENDIX B.**

2. If this study is being performed at sites other than the Reed College campus or online, please list the other sites:

3. Has this study received governmental funding and/or funding from an agency that requires certification of review by the Reed College IRB?

☐ YES ☒ NO

If YES, list funding information (including agency and protocol number) and append a copy of the funding application.

4. Does the research require approval from one or more non-Reed organization(s) or IRB(s)?

☐ YES ☒ NO

If YES, attach application(s) to other organization(s) and, if approval has been granted, documentation of the approval.

5. Does the research include in-person research activities?

☒ YES ☐ NO

6. Does the research include participants residing in the **European Union (EU)**, the **European Economic Area (EEA)**, the **United Kingdom**, and/or the **People's Republic of China (PRC)**?

☐ YES ☒ NO

If No, please be sure to exclude individuals residing in the EU, EEA, UK, and PRC from your recruitment mechanisms.

If YES, please note that the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) applies to all individuals residing in the EU, EEA, and UK and that the Personal Information Protection Law (PIPL) applies if personally identifiable information is collected in the PRC. Please contact IRB Chair Luda Korobenko and IRB Administrator Kayla Johnston to ensure that your research will be in compliance with these regulations.

7. **CATEGORY OF REVIEW**.
Although the IRB ultimately determines which type of review your protocol will receive, please consult the guidelines on the webpage entitled "Categories of Review" and then check the category of review you believe applies. Please note that research involving minors is not eligible for Exempt Categories 2 and 3. The minimum category for research with minors is Expedited.

- ☐ Exempt Category 1: Educational Practices **(no need to complete the remainder of this form)**
- ☐ Exempt Category 2: Educational Tests, Survey Procedures, Interview Procedures, or Observation of Public Behavior (will undergo Limited Review). **In order to qualify for this category, the research must be considered benign to participants.**
- ☐ Exempt Category 3: Benign Behavioral Interventions (will undergo Limited Review)
- ☐ Exempt Category 4: Use of secondary data for which consent is not currently required **(answer the following three questions (8-10), but no need to complete the remainder of this form)**
- ☒ Expedited (considered minimal risk to human subjects)
- ☐ Full (considered above minimal risk to human subjects)

Questions 8-12 are required for Exempt Category 4 only:
8. Provide a brief description of the data and the source of the data.

9. Which of the following applies?

☐ The identifiable personal information is publicly available.

☐ The identifiable personal information was de-identified such that participant identities cannot readily be ascertained, and the investigator will not contact or re-identify participants.

10. Was the data collected in compliance with the Common Rule (if in the US) or international data regulations (if outside the US)?

☐ YES ☐ NO ☐ NOT APPLICABLE

11. How will you access or receive this data?

12. Is there anything else you wish to share about this data and your proposed research?

C. PARTICIPANTS (required for Exempt Categories 2 and 3, Expedited, and Full review categories)

1. How many participants do you anticipate?

I aim for 6 total participants; 2 conversation partner participants, and 4 speaker participants.

2. Describe the sample population.

I intend to recruit four transfeminine individuals, one trans woman, and one cis woman, all from the Reed College student body.

3. How will participants be recruited?

The two conversation partner participants will be committing to more visits and interviews than the other participants. For this reason, I plan to recruit them from people I know via email and word-of-mouth. I plan to use posters and word-of-mouth, with follow up emails, to recruit speaker participants.

4. What individuals or groups of individuals will be included or excluded, and why?

Individuals under the age of 18 will be excluded to ensure all participants are able to provide legal consent. Men, and nonbinary people who do not identify with the term "transfeminine", will be excluded to control for gender. Non-English speakers will be excluded, as the study is limited to the investigation of speech in English.

ACTION: Please upload all recruitment materials to the IRB Portal. Examples of recruitment documents can be found on the IRB website under *Participant Recruitment Materials*. Be sure to include the following information on recruitment materials: expected duration of individual participation, study location, and type or amount of compensation to participants, if any.

D. CONFIDENTIALITY AND PRIVACY (required for Exempt Categories 2 and 3, Expedited, and Full review categories)

1. Will you be collecting any identifiable personal information (e.g., names, social security numbers,

detailed physical descriptions, genealogies, addresses, photographs, video or audio recordings, IP addresses, etc.)?

☒ YES ☐ NO

2. Will you be collecting information that, in light of the potential participant pool, could lead to the identification of an individual participant? Examples include autobiographical accounts or identifiable patterns of demographic information given the sample population.

☒ YES ☐ NO

If YES to either of these questions, describe confidentiality procedures, what will become of records after use (e.g., shown at scientific meetings, erased), the final disposition of the records (e.g., destruction, archiving), and a reasonable timeline for this disposition.

The data I plan to collect are: name, email address, recordings of speech, transcripts of speech, and demographic survey responses. Name, email address, consent form, the information linking name to pseudonym and name to email address will be kept confidential; I will not share them with my thesis advisor, any potential future research collaborators, or anybody else. These identifiable data will be stored securely in a password-protected encrypted folder which will be deleted by May 14, 2026. A separate encrypted folder, protected by a different password, will be used to store audio recordings, transcripts, and survey responses. Names, as well as any other information participants choose, will be deleted from transcripts, audio recordings, and survey responses before storage. I will only store audio recordings, transcripts, and survey responses under participants' pseudonyms. These folders will be stored on my private computer in separate locations, and another copy will be backed up to my private Reed College Google Drive (under the same password-locked encryption). My consent form gives participants the option for all copies of the second folder containing audio recordings, transcripts, and survey responses to be deleted once this study is completed (May 14, 2026), or to be stored indefinitely for use in any future research I conduct. Survey responses will be shared with the public through my thesis and any of my future publications. As there is some risk of identification from the reporting of demographic survey responses due to the small participant pool, I explain this in the consent form, and participants are encouraged not to respond to any questions which they think may uniquely identify them, and given opportunities to change their answers or redact any answers they would like. Participants who agree to indefinite storage for future research can additionally opt to allow me to share audio recordings and transcripts with any future research collaborators. Participants may also opt to allow me to quote, excerpt, or paraphrase from redacted forms of their transcripts, and my consent form indicates the risk that this could inadvertently reveal identifiable details. I will not share audio recordings with anyone other than my thesis advisor and these potential collaborators. Sharing of audio recordings and transcripts with my thesis advisor and potential future collaborators will take place through the sharing of the second password-protected encrypted folder via google drive. My thesis advisor and possible future research collaborators will not share this information further with others, and maintain the secure password-protected storage of this data in an encrypted folder. I will only share the password for access to this folder in a private in-person interaction. My advisor and collaborators will not be permitted to use this data in publications of which I am not co-author, and will not quote, excerpt, and or paraphrase transcript content outside of publications of which I am co-author. They will delete their copies of the data once our collaboration is finished.

3. If you are collecting data online, please refer to our website FAQ for issues related to online research, and discuss here how you will protect participant confidentiality (e.g., collection of IP addresses, use of

Amazon Mechanical Turk, etc.).

4. If data are identified by a code, will you retain a master list linking codes and direct identifiers?

☒ YES ☐ NO

If YES, explain how and where you will secure the master list, and how long it will be kept.

There will be a master list of names to pseudonyms stored in the first folder mentioned in the question above. This folder will be a password-protected encrypted folder of which there are two copies, one on my computer and one on my Reed College google drive. This folder will be deleted by May 14, 2026. This folder will be stored separately from the folder containing audio recordings, transcripts, and survey responses. This folder will not be shared with my thesis advisor, any potential future research collaborators, or anybody else.

5. Will information that could identify participants be shared in any way?

☒ YES ☐ NO

If YES, explain.

Although survey procedures are intended to keep participants' identities confidential, the content of their speech and their demographic survey responses, which will all only be shared under their pseudonym, have the risk of being identifiable. This is largely because the potential participant pool, Reed College students who identify with the label "transfeminine" and are between the ages of 18 and 21, is relatively small. For this reason, demographic information will not be shared in high levels of specificity. My consent form highlights these identifiability risks, and discourages participants from sharing any information or answering any questions which may uniquely identify them among the potential participant pool. My procedure gives participants the opportunity to redact any information they later feel may be identifiable, or are otherwise uncomfortable sharing. An additional risk of identification comes from the fact that I am conducting conversations between two participants, and I cannot control what participants share about their co-participants, although I will explain to participants that sharing information about their co-participants is potentially harmful and should be avoided. It is also possible that my thesis advisor and (if permitted) any future research collaborators may be able to identify participants by the sound of their voice in audio recordings or by details in their transcript which evaded the redaction process.

E. INFORMED CONSENT (required for Exempt Categories 2 and 3, Expedited, and Full review categories)

The consent form should be a plain-language description of key information designed to facilitate comprehension and informed decision making (e.g., who will obtain consent, how and where the consent process will take place). It should also include specific information about how participant privacy and confidentiality will be protected. Please read the Participant Consent page on our website thoroughly, including the consent form templates provided. Then indicate what form of consent you will seek from participants, and **ATTACH the appropriate consent form or script.**

NOTES: (1) If the research includes audio or video recordings, your consent document/script should include a separate line asking for consent to record. (2) If you plan to archive potentially identifiable data for future use, your consent document/script should include a separate line asking for consent to

archive.

1. How will informed consent be sought from participants?

☒ **Written consent**

☐ **Oral consent**

☐ **Implied consent**

2. Where will the consent process take place?

☒ In person

Describe where: Reed Campus at the Lab of Linguistics in Eliot 101D, just before study activities.

☐ Online

☐ Other

Describe:

F. PROCEDURES (required for Exempt Categories 2 and 3, Expedited, and Full review categories)

ATTACH all questionnaires and surveys, and include sample items from computerized tasks. For structured interviews, provide your interview protocol. For unstructured interviews, provide sample questions and describe the goals of the interview. If Expedited or Full, please provide a more detailed description of the procedures, including specific information on what each participant will be asked to experience or do.

After expressing interest in participation, participants will be sent a copy of the consent form for their reference. We will then schedule a private one-on-one meeting in the Lab of Linguistics to discuss any questions the participant may have, decide on a pseudonym, and get the consent form signed. Then, speaker will meet one of the conversation partner participants and introduce themselves to one another under their pseudonyms. Participants will be oriented to the study and the recording equipment. Once they are ready, I will verbally confirm their consent for me to record and announce the start of the recording. I will then leave the room. They will have been told to first collaboratively complete a crossword puzzle and then spend the rest of the allotted time getting to know each other, trying to find things in common in their life experiences. A sample script for my prompt for their conversations is attached. After the timer ends, I will knock on the door, enter, and announce the end of the recording. This will be repeated for each speaker participant with both conversation partner participants. Then, participants will be asked to complete the survey which I have attached. After they have finished the survey, a last recording session will take place, in which I will ask follow-up questions to survey responses, and ask more open-ended questions about their gender, sexuality, their social circle, and their experiences with gender. I will also seek to get to know them more broadly to help contextualize my understanding of them as an individual. A document detailing the interview procedure for the trans participants, as well as for the cis participant, is attached. They will then be debriefed on any questions which I deferred the answer to until debriefing; the only questions I would defer would pertain to the specifics of what aspects of their voice I am interested in studying. After this, their participation will be complete.

G. RISK/BENEFIT ASSESSMENT (required for Expedited and Full review categories only)

1. Benefits

Describe the potential direct and indirect benefits, if any, to participants (excluding incentives).

none

2. Risks

Indicate whether the research involves any of the following by checking the applicable items:

☐ Deception of participants

☒ Procedures that may result in mental or emotional stress, such as induction of negative mood, damage to self-esteem, manipulation of attitudes, or exposure to aversive stimuli

☐ Procedures that may involve physical harm to participants, such as ingestion of a substance, physical exercise, or invasive physiological measurements

☐ Presentation of materials and/or behaviors commonly regarded as socially unacceptable within the setting of the research

☒ Observations or questions that might be regarded as invading privacy, especially if these might lead to disclosure of information that could be harmful to participants (e.g., criminal behavior, immigration status, information that might affect academic or employment status, information that could affect the participant's reputation or be considered stigmatizing)

3. For each of the items checked above, describe why each is necessary, and how you will seek to minimize each risk posed.

The goal of my study is to understand if and why trans people might change their voice based on the trans status of the person they are talking to. In order to do this, it is important to have a full picture of each participant's gender identity, trans experience, social circle, aspects of their body relevant to the voice, and, perhaps most sensitively, their experiences with transphobia, and attitudes on interaction with cis people, and understandings of how they are seen by others. Another sensitive area I intend to ask about is whether participants have received/undergone any medical gender-related or speech-related procedures/therapies as well, as these variables must be controlled for a sound quantitative analysis.

In order to minimize the risk of emotional distress and the feeling of invasion of privacy, all questions are optional, and I will encourage participants not to answer any question which makes them uncomfortable, and only to answer with an amount of detail which feels safe and comfortable to them. In the case that emotional distress does occur, questions and recording will be stopped without loss of incentive, and I will refer the participant to a list of mental and trans health resources, including the health and counseling center, the Reed 24/7 Crisis Counseling Hotline (866-432-1224), the Trans Lifeline (877-565-8860), and the Racial Equity Support line (503-575-3764). The participant will be allowed to leave at any time without loss of incentive, and leaving will be taken as withdrawal from the study and data on that participant will be deleted, unless the participant indicates that they would still like to be included either in the moment or in a follow-up conversation with me.